

Birds

This month it's House Sparrows

The House Sparrow, *Passer Domesticus*, one of 18 varieties in the *passer* species throughout the world. Lives in open, dry country – bush, savanna, desert; also forest, woodland cultivation, high mountain country and human habitation just like our House Sparrow. It's highly urbanized and among the most successful of all birds.



Male



Female

Sometimes described as a tubby finch with broad wings and a square ended tail. – warm brown, boldly patterned, greyish underparts, with a lead-grey crown, the male with black eye stripe and bib, Mind you in August when they moult the male acquires a more brownish-buff plumage and its black bib is not so obvious.



If they're nearby you hear them all the time – chatty but monotonous chip, chap or cheerp, and quite loud when they're in flocks. The house sparrow is a very social bird. It roosts communally and engages in social activities such as dust or water bathing and "social singing".

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They nest in holes, but they're skilful at building a nest in trees and hedges, with a roof and a side entrance.



Because they don't migrate they get a jump start on claiming nest boxes.

Egg laying is usually in April with 3-5 in a clutch, 11-14 days incubation and another 11-19 days to fledge.

Both sexes build, incubate and brood their young and feed them for up to 2 weeks after fledging.

At feeding stations and nests, female house sparrows are dominant despite their smaller size, and they can fight over males in the breeding season.



There's been a decline since the 70s, maybe a lack of suitable nesting sites -



improved under eaves in our houses? But now they're flocking back to our gardens,

Cats and birds of prey are their biggest predators.

I've noticed there's a young ginger cat close by who is turning into a bird watcher, especially sparrow watching.

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Their main food is seeds and insects and Peter remembers huge flocks of sparrows clearing fields of grain – not popular with farmers.

But the house sparrow itself has long been used as a food item. From around 1560 to at least the 19th century in northern Europe, earthenware "sparrow pots" were hung from eaves to attract nesting birds so the young could be readily harvested.

They have often been eaten and in some places still are. Sparrow pie was a



common rural dish in Britain up to the time of the First World War, and even later: a sparrow pie containing 100 sparrows was served on 16 January 1967 at the Rose Inn at Peldon, near Colchester, perhaps for the remaining members of one of the "sparrow clubs" that were once common for trapping the birds.

“Sparrows pay the price

The start of a classical guitar recital being given by Konrad Ragossnig on 2 August 1979 in St Helen's Church, Brant Broughton, Lincolnshire, was delayed by the chirping of a cock sparrow. The rector pronounced a sentence of death, and had the bird shot so the concert could proceed uninterrupted. He met with widespread criticism.

A sparrow has also been executed more recently for interfering with an attempt in the Netherlands to establish a world record in collapsing more than 4 million dominos in one grand "domino effect". The sparrow managed to collapse 23,000 of them before the organiser, the TV company Endemol, had it shot. It, too, was widely criticised, and subsequently fined.” From *The Independent: The Secret Life of Sparrows*